Buying a home, step by step

Check off each step and write down the date. Your contract sets the real deadlines, so ask your agent or lender when something is due. Pages 3 and 4 have a home tour checklist and a sheet to compare homes.

Before you shop

Getting ready

- [ ] **Check your credit score**
  Higher scores get better rates. Free reports at annualcreditreport.com.
  DATE
- [ ] **Set your budget**
  Count the whole monthly cost: loan, taxes, insurance, HOA and upkeep, not just the price.
  DATE
- [ ] **Get pre-approved for a mortgage**
  Sellers take offers more seriously with a pre-approval letter. Compare a few lenders.
  DATE
- [ ] **Save for down payment and closing costs**
  Closing costs usually run 2–5% of the price, on top of the down payment.
  DATE
- [ ] **Find a buyer's agent**
  Ask how they're paid and what they charge before you sign.
  DATE
- [ ] **List your must-haves**
  Bedrooms, schools, commute, yard. Decide what you won't compromise on.
  DATE
- [ ] **Tour homes and compare them**
  Use the tour checklist on page 3 at every showing, then the comparison sheet on page 4.
  DATE

Under contract

The first few weeks after your offer is accepted

- [ ] **Pay the earnest money deposit**
  Usually due within a few days of signing. Confirm wire instructions by phone first.
  DATE
- [ ] **Schedule the home inspection**
  Most contracts give you 7–10 days. Go along and ask questions.
  DATE
- [ ] **Review the inspection and request repairs**
  Ask for repairs or a credit before your inspection deadline.
  DATE
- [ ] **Lock your interest rate**
  Ask your lender how long the lock lasts and what an extension costs.
  DATE
- [ ] **Send your lender the documents they ask for**
  Pay stubs, bank statements, tax returns. Respond quickly to avoid delays.
  DATE
- [ ] **Buy homeowners insurance**
  Your lender needs proof of insurance before closing. Get a few quotes.
  DATE
- [ ] **Appraisal**
  Your lender orders it. If it comes in low, talk with your agent about options.
  DATE
- [ ] **Review the title report**
  Check for liens or problems with ownership. Ask the title company about anything unclear.
  DATE

Closing and moving in

The last few weeks go fast. Book the big things early and keep this page with your closing papers.

Closing soon

About three weeks out

- [ ] **Book movers or a truck** — DATE
  Weekends and month-ends fill up fast.
- [ ] **Set up utilities in your name** — DATE
  Electric, gas, water and sewer, internet and trash. Call ahead so service starts on move-in day.
- [ ] **Forward your mail** — DATE
  Change your address with USPS, your bank, employer and subscriptions.
- [ ] **Review your Closing Disclosure** — DATE
  You'll get it at least 3 business days before closing. Compare it to your Loan Estimate.
- [ ] **Confirm wire instructions by phone** — DATE
  Call the title company at a number you already trust before sending money.
- [ ] **Do the final walkthrough** — DATE
  Check that agreed repairs are done and nothing's changed.

Watch for wire fraud

Scammers send fake emails that look like they're from your agent or title company, with new wire instructions. Never trust wiring details sent by email. Call a number you already know before you send anything.

Bring to closing

- [ ] Photo ID for every buyer
- [ ] Cashier's check or confirmed wire
  For the amount on your Closing Disclosure
- [ ] Proof of homeowners insurance
- [ ] Your copy of the Closing Disclosure
- [ ] A pen, and time to read before you sign

Your first week

- [ ] Change the locks and garage codes
- [ ] Find the water shutoff and breaker panel
- [ ] Test smoke and carbon monoxide alarms
- [ ] Replace the furnace filter
  Write the size here: _____
- [ ] Learn trash and recycling days
- [ ] Ask your county about a homestead tax break
- [ ] Note your first mortgage payment date
- [ ] Keep closing papers in one safe place

Keep it going in the Tallihaus app

Tallihaus keeps this checklist with real due dates, then tracks your mortgage, bills, appliances and upkeep once you move in.

For iPhone and Mac
tallihaus.com

Home tour checklist

ADDRESS _____ ASKING PRICE _____ DATE TOURED _____

Mark **Good** or **Concern** for each one. Concerns are worth asking the seller or your inspector about.

Outside

	GOOD	CONCERN
Roof Missing, curling or patchy shingles; sagging lines	☐	☐
Gutters & downspouts Attached, not overflowing, draining away	☐	☐
Siding & paint Peeling paint, soft or rotting wood, cracks	☐	☐
Foundation Cracks wider than a coin, bowing or leaning walls	☐	☐
Yard drainage Ground slopes away from the house; no pooling	☐	☐
Windows Foggy double panes, rotted frames, drafts	☐	☐
Driveway & walkways Big cracks, heaving or crumbling concrete	☐	☐

Inside

	GOOD	CONCERN
Ceilings & walls Water stains, fresh paint in just one spot, cracks	☐	☐
Floors Soft spots, sloping, worn or damaged spots	☐	☐
Smells Musty, smoke or pets; candles can hide them	☐	☐
Doors & windows open Sticking doors can mean settling	☐	☐
Outlets & switches Bring a phone charger to test a few outlets	☐	☐
Basement or crawl space Dampness, chalky walls, a working sump pump	☐	☐

Kitchen & baths

	GOOD	CONCERN
Kitchen appliances Check the age on labels; most last 10–15 years	☐	☐
Water pressure Run the shower and a sink at the same time	☐	☐
Drains & under sinks Slow drains, leaks or water damage in cabinets	☐	☐
Toilets Flush well, don't rock, no stains around the base	☐	☐
Tub & shower Cracked grout or caulk, soft walls around the tub	☐	☐

Systems

	GOOD	CONCERN
Furnace & AC Find the label for its age; ask for service records	☐	☐
Water heater Age is on the label; look for rust or leaks	☐	☐
Electrical panel Breakers, labeled, no rust or scorch marks	☐	☐
Washer & dryer Ask if they're included in the sale	☐	☐

Neighborhood

	GOOD	CONCERN
Noise Traffic, trains, flight paths, neighbors	☐	☐
Parking & street Easy parking, safe street, sidewalks	☐	☐
Cell signal Check bars in a few rooms	☐	☐
Natural light Which way the main rooms face	☐	☐

NOTES AND QUESTIONS FOR THE SELLER

Compare homes side by side

Fill in one column per home. The listing has most of the facts; the ages come from equipment labels and the seller's disclosure.

	Home 1	Home 2	Home 3
Address			
THE BASICS			
Asking price			
Beds / baths			
Square feet			
Year built			
Lot and yard			
COSTS			
Property tax Per year, from the listing			
HOA dues Per month			
Insurance quote Per year			
Total monthly payment Ask your lender			
AGE AND CONDITION			
Roof age			
Furnace & AC age			
Water heater age			
Concerns from the tour Count from page 3			
Repairs you'd need			
LIVING THERE			
Commute			
Schools			
Must-haves it meets			
Gut feeling 1 to 5			

A rough rule: roofs last about 20–25 years, furnaces 15–20, water heaters 8–12. Older ones aren't a deal-breaker, but budget for them.